

# Supreme Court Hears a Big Case About Climate Change

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On Monday, the U.S. **Supreme Court** listened to **arguments** in an important case about **climate change**.

Leaders in Boulder, Colorado, are **suing** two energy companies, Suncor and ExxonMobil. Boulder says **climate change** causes natural disasters that cost the city money. It wants the companies to help pay. Boulder also says the companies were not honest about oil and gas. The companies say they are not to blame. Their lawyer, Kannon Shanmugam, said more than two dozen cases like this are going on around the country. The companies say these cases could cost billions of dollars.

Only eight of the nine **justices** heard the case. Justice Samuel Alito stepped aside because he owns stock in oil and gas companies. If the vote is a 4-4 tie, an earlier Colorado **ruling** that let Boulder's case go forward will stay in place.

Expert Amy Howe said it was hard to tell how the court will decide. A decision may not come until early next year.

## Word Treasure

**Supreme Court** -- The Supreme Court is the highest court in the United States.

**arguments** -- Arguments are the reasons lawyers give to convince judges.

**climate change** -- Climate change is the long-term warming of Earth's weather patterns.

**suing** -- Suing means asking a court to make someone pay for harm or fix a problem.

**justices** -- Justices are the judges on the Supreme Court.

**ruling** -- A ruling is a decision made by a court.

## Background you need

The Supreme Court has nine justices who decide very important questions about the law. Climate change is the warming of Earth, which scientists link mostly to burning oil, gas and coal.

When a court case is a tie, the decision from the lower court stays in place.

## Break it down

**WHO:** Leaders in Boulder, Colorado, and the energy companies Suncor and ExxonMobil

**WHAT:** The Supreme Court heard arguments about whether the companies should help pay for climate disaster costs

**WHERE:** The U.S. Supreme Court

**WHY:** Boulder says climate change causes costly disasters and the companies were not honest about oil and gas

## Why it matters

The court's decision could affect who pays when climate change damages the places where kids and families live.

## Test what you remember

**1. Which city is suing the energy companies?**

- ☐ (A) Paris, France
- ☐ (B) Boulder, Colorado
- ☐ (C) Austin, Texas
- ☐ (D) Denver, Colorado

**2. What does Boulder want the companies to do?**

- ☐ (A) Close forever
- ☐ (B) Move to another state
- ☐ (C) Build a new park
- ☐ (D) Help pay for disaster costs

**3. How many justices heard the case?**

- ☐ (A) Nine
- ☐ (B) Two
- ☐ (C) Eight
- ☐ (D) Five

**4. Why did Justice Samuel Alito step aside?**

- ☐ (A) He was on vacation
- ☐ (B) He lives in Boulder
- ☐ (C) He is a lawyer for Boulder
- ☐ (D) He owns stock in oil and gas companies

**5. What happens if the vote is a 4-4 tie?**

- ☐ (A) The companies win
- ☐ (B) The case is thrown away
- ☐ (C) The president decides
- ☐ (D) An earlier Colorado ruling stays in place

**6. When might a decision come?**

- ☐ (A) Early next year
- ☐ (B) Tomorrow
- ☐ (C) Last week
- ☐ (D) Never

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: C 4: D 5: D 6: A

## Questions to think about

- 1. Boulder leaders:** They say the companies should help pay for disasters caused by climate change.
- 2. Energy companies:** They say they are not to blame and that these cases could cost billions of dollars.

**MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):**